

took off while North fell only by 10 per cent.”

What made him put all his money into the South? A big reason was that Wipro Consumer had a strong distribution network in south India, where its Sunflower *vanaspati* brand sold a lot. FMCG majors can use the same distribution network to reach every corner with any product. Says Parameswaran, “During that period, they understood the power of the regional media. Besides, Santoor has stuck to the Mummy theme to make it more relevant to today’s woman.”

Santoor got unexpected traction from HLL’s 2001 “power-brand strategy”. When HLL (renamed Hindustan Unilever Ltd or HUL in 2007) decided to focus on 30 brands out of its portfolio of over 100, its sandalwood soap Moti was not on the list. Santoor now had no rival nationally or regionally (Mysore Sandal Soap, a premium brand, was restricted to Karnataka).

Ranju Mohan, FMCG veteran and Founder of Iki-grow, a start-up specialising in personal care, says the Santoor strategy was executed well. “Consolidating in the South was a smart thing to do since the region has high brand loyalty. The brand got it right on its focus, built a hypothesis, and rolled it out well,” he says. The extension into premium areas like handwash will always be a challenge. “Selling premium brands needs better storytelling, a lot of patience and a new approach. Besides, the consumer has not outgrown the usage of soap.” In 2019, Santoor became the first Indian soap to cross ₹2,000 crore in revenues, overtaking HUL’s Lux. Only Lifebuoy is larger.

Wipro Consumer has not had it easy with other brands, such as Softouch, a fabric conditioner brand pitted against HUL’s Comfort. Rohit Srivastava, Chief Strategy Officer of Contract Advertising, the agency that handles the brand, says it is important to play the disruptor and try to persuade the consumer. “Our research showed how the competition was functioning, and we saw an opportunity in the emotional route,” he says, adding that led Wipro to use fragrance in its 2X French Perfume variant of the conditioner. And fragrance “became the brand’s core message”.

Agrawal says Wipro Consumer’s product portfolio (there is also a homecare business apart from hygiene, male grooming, lighting and office solutions) is much smaller than those of multinationals. “We are still building it, and the process will take time,” he says.

But how do light bulbs (which Wipro entered in 1991) sit next to soaps? Agrawal retorts that light bulbs sit very well next to soaps in grocery shops, explaining how Wipro Consumer has a significant competitive

HOW WIPRO GOT

THE ₹1,000-CRORE PORTFOLIO



SANTOOR
2,650



B2B LIGHTING BUSINESS
1,000



ENCHANTEUR
1,000

FIGURES INDICATE FY23 REVENUES IN ₹ CRORE

THE SANTOOR JOURNEY

Year	Revenue (₹ crore)
FY96	61
FY06	295
FY11	809
FY16	1,708
FY19	2,052
FY23	2,650

SOURCE COMPANY

“Santoor was a clear disruption and focussed on the mom. It was not just about the skin but making a woman feel young... Besides, Santoor has stuck to the Mummy theme to make it more relevant to today’s woman”



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